

Great thinkers

The pursuit of knowledge has inspired and influenced people since ancient times. The first philosophers wanted to understand the world around them and sought ways to make it a better place. Over the centuries and across the continents, new concepts and powerful theories have developed our understanding, expanded our learning, and encouraged ideas about equality, justice, and freedom.

China's great teacher

Kong Fuzi (or Confucius)

Where China

When 551–479 BCE

Ancient Chinese philosopher and politician Confucius ran a school out of his own home. His teachings were based on “Five virtues”—*Ren* (benevolence), *Yi* (righteousness), *Li* (right behavior), *Zhi* (knowledge and wisdom), and *Xin* (trustworthiness)—each crucial for a happy life. His belief system is called Confucianism, and it eventually became the state religion of China in c. 202 BCE.



Ancient Greek thinkers

Plato and Aristotle



Plato is holding his book *Timaeus*.

Aristotle with his book *Ethics*

Where Greece

When c. 427–c. 347 BCE (Plato), 384–322 BCE (Aristotle)

Greek philosopher Plato (far left) founded a school called the Academy in Athens, which became famous throughout Greece. In one of his important works, *The Republic*, he discussed his idea of a perfect society and how it would be governed. Among his students was Aristotle (left), who wrote more than 200 books on different subjects, such as classifying animals. These philosophers are regarded as two of the world's greatest thinkers, whose ideas helped shape Western culture.

Arab polymath

Abu Yusuf Ya'qub ibn Isbaq al-Sabbah al-Kindi

Where Abbasid Caliphate (modern-day Iraq)

When c. 800–870

A great scholar, al-Kindi transformed philosophy and science in the Islamic world. His extensive writings included books on the nature of God, a mathematical work about parallel lines, and a set of four books about the Indian number system. He also led a team of translators to convert the works of Greek philosophers into Arabic.

